

A Short Story: Slippery [C1]

Il protagonista di questo racconto è nato con la straordinaria capacità di sfuggire a qualsiasi situazione. Ma un uomo assunto dalle vittime delle sue truffe riesce a catturarlo in un modo che lui non avrebbe mai immaginato.



I have been a [slippery](#) character since the day I was born. Seconds after the [midwife](#) cut the umbilical cord, [I wriggled](#), [slipped out](#) of her hands and fell to the floor. Fortunately I was born at home; I owe my life to the thick [carpet](#) in my parents' bedroom. My parents could never hug or [tickle](#) me. Throwing me into the air and catching me was completely out of the question. Their inability to show their affection in any tangible way worried them. They took me to a child psychologist, but by that time I'd invented an explanation for my behaviour, which convinced everyone. I was never involved in any physical altercations at school. I enjoyed provoking the [school bullies](#), but while they tried to [beat me up](#) I always [slipped out](#) from their rugby-style [tackles](#) like a bar of soap. I had few friends and was equally unpopular with the staff. If the teachers tried to reprimand me for a [cheeky](#) comment or incomplete homework, they soon discovered that my tongue was as [slippery](#) as the rest of me. My [ready](#) excuses and explanations left them in [bewildered](#) silence. I didn't bother with university, but went straight from school to a job, several in fact, and I moved between my various roles — [bartender](#), [courier](#), circus escapologist and part-time thief — with the greatest of [ease](#). I signed no contracts and paid no taxes. I gave a false name and address to each of my employers, so if ever I had to leave suddenly, they were unable [to get hold of](#) me. All that changed the day I saw Bernard. Sitting at a small table in the corner of the restaurant where I was working as a waiter, he was one of the few single [diners](#) not [peering](#) at a smartphone. A large man — not fat, but robust and imposing — Bernard looked neither [awkward](#) nor isolated. Although I wasn't his waiter that evening, I frequently noticed him watching me. If our eyes crossed, he smiled and looked away. At the end of the meal he [summoned](#) another waiter and [settled his bill](#), but then passed close by me as he headed for the exit. I was so sure he was going to stop and say something, I raised my [eyebrows](#) and looked at him expectantly, but he walked past me and out onto the street. I felt [foolish](#) and [annoyed](#). I thought about him all that evening and most of the next day. Bernard came back three or four times and the same thing happened. Whenever I caught him looking, he would smile and look away. The worst thing was, I felt strangely [drawn](#) to him. I, who had spent a lifetime [slipping away](#) from people, felt an irresistible urge not only to approach him, but to get to know him. It was a fierce magnetism. Eventually I could [stand it no longer](#). The last time he left, I [hurried out](#) of the restaurant just in time to see him disappearing down an [alley](#). I ran after him, but when I got to the [alley](#) it was deserted. I was fast on my feet, but this large man had managed to [outstrip](#) me. I started jogging down the [alley](#) when suddenly a great hand grabbed me by the neck and [lifted me off my feet](#). That's when Bernard introduced himself. I squirmed and kicked but he'd [trapped](#) some of my hair in his fist and I couldn't move without [wrenching](#) it at the [roots](#). "I wouldn't waste too much effort trying to wriggle out of this one," he said in a voice that was deep and strangely calming. "There are some people who'd like to have a word with you." "Who?" I [gasped](#). Bernard recited a long list of names: all people I'd robbed or [swindled](#) and then slipped away from. They'd [reached out](#) to each other on social media, sharing old photographs of me in

various [guises](#) before hiring Bernard to track me down. Bernard forced me to his car. “You won’t mind travelling in the back,” he said softly as he opened the [boot](#). I shook my head and he [gagged](#) and tied me up, then lifted me in with surprising gentleness. I wasn’t worried — I’d escaped from similar situations several times in one of my circus jobs. Poor Bernard really thought that leaving me tied up in the [boot](#) of his car in a locked garage would be enough to control me until his clients arrived. I watched them from the roof of a neighbouring garage as they [lined up](#), waiting expectantly. I felt truly sorry for Bernard as he opened the garage door, then flung the [boot](#) open, only to find it empty. But Bernard has me well and truly [trapped](#). I moved away and found another job, but I still feel irresistibly [drawn](#) to the calm and [mighty](#) man who temporarily caught me. I’ve visited the garage several times, but Bernard hasn’t been back. When he comes, I’ll follow him home, then somehow I’ll find a way to slip back into his life.

Glossary

- **tackles** = placcaggi
- **ready** = rapide, pronte
- **annoyed** = infastidita
- **drawn** = attratta
- **stand it no longer** = non potevo più sopportarli
- **hurried out** = uscire di fretta
- **wrenching** = strattonare
- **roots** = radici
- **bewildered** = sbalordito, confuso
- **settled his bill** = pagare il conto
- **foolish** = stupida
- **boot open** = aprire di colpo
- **school bullies** = bulli, prepotenti
- **awkward** = goffo
- **slippery** = sfuggente
- **midwife** = ostetrica
- **I wriggled** = contorcersi
- **summoned** = chiamare
- **guises** = maschere
- **mighty** = potente
- **carpet** = tappeto
- **cheeky** = impertinente
- **courier** = postina
- **slipped out** = sfuggire
- **tickle** = fare il solletico
- **to get hold of** = prendere
- **peering** = guardare da vicino, scrutare
- **eyebrows** = sopracciglia
- **slipping away** = sfuggire
- **lifted me off my feet** = alzare da terra
- **ease** = facilità, con disinvoltura
- **diners** = commensali
- **gasped** = ansimare
- **swindled** = truffare
- **reached out** = contattare
- **boot** = bagagliaio
- **gagged** = soffocare
- **beat me up** = picchiare
- **bartender** = barista
- **alley** = strada

- **outstrip** = avanzare
- **trapped** = prendere
- **lined up** = fare una fila